

I read the advertisements for the Sunservice hot line, for the special discount on a family portrait, for the all-in-one account, for the credit card with no yearly fee, and for the Sunline Equity loan.

Eventually, I was assigned to an officer, Jane Gautier, who at least looked old enough to vote. Others I'd seen would have been refused a beer. Ms. Gautier said there'd be no toaster, no free money, no incentive awards, no prizes of any kind to accompany my deposit. I told her it sounded like Sun Bank really didn't want my money, and she shook her head in agreement. She expected I'd get a better deal elsewhere. It's sad to be turned down for a loan, but being discouraged from opening a savings account is an insult.

Centrust Savings, was more solicitous. Julio, a young officer in a checkered tie that was no match for his striped shirt, insisted that Centrust's superior rate of interest made up for any lack of prizes. He recommended the two-and-a-half-year Head Start savings, which returned 10 percent for three months and 6.34 percent thereafter, for a combined 7.20 percent average yield or 7.52 percent annual yield for the full term. He explained the difference between average and annual yield three times, and still I didn't understand it. I'd heard similar explanations dozens of times before, and I never understood them then or since.

(I suspect that bankers know we're baffled by such things as compound yields, and this confusion allows them to pay us whatever amount of interest they feel like paying at any given time. Since I'd have to comprehend average yield and annual yield before I could prove this, it seems futile to pursue the matter any further.)

When I asked if I could borrow any money I decided to invest in Centrust Savings, Julio's face brightened appreciably. "Of course you can," he said, "up to 90 percent." He went on to describe how a loan could be structured for interest only, with the due date set to coincide exactly with the expiration of a certificate of deposit. Then he introduced me to the Equity Credit line—no fees, no closing costs, and approval in 48 hours—through which I could borrow even more on the equity in my house. The interest rate could be fixed or variable.

In all the various banks and S&Ls, I sensed a greater enthusiasm for increasing my indebtedness than for encouraging my savings,